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WARNER CENTER - Residents rally for cleanup of rocket site - They want former Rocketdyne facility to meet water standards

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Several residents and activists on Thursday called for the cleanup of the 47-acre former Rocketdyne site in Warner Center where massive rocket engines were once built.

“This facility needs to be made safe for future generations to live, work, play, and pray on,” said Jane Williams, executive director of California Communities Against Toxics, during the rally. “The current proposal fails to deliver on that goal.”

The prospect of people living at the site has emerged now that the area is part of the Warner Center 2035 Specific Plan, adopted in 2013 to attract thousands of new residential homes into the area.

Triple Five Group Ltd., the owner of the Mall of America, was eyeing the former Rocketdyne site.

Activists fear shallow groundwater has substantially contributed to high levels of contaminants in soil vapor on and off the site.

Organizers with Valley Residents for a Safe Environment said they gathered more than 4,000 signatures from Valley residents, urging the Los Angeles Regional Water Control Board to order additional environmental testing of the soil and groundwater and hold the landowner, United Technologies Corp., accountable for full remediation.

UTC spokeswoman Michele

Quintaglie said in an email the company’s “priority has always been, and remains to be, to work with LARWCB to clean up the property so that it can be used for residential purposes, consistent with community goals.”

She said that UTC is “committed to ensuring that our efforts are in full compliance with all local, state and federal laws and regulations. We take seriously our environmental, health and safety responsibilities, and look forward to continuing to partner with all stakeholders on this matter.”

The site, 6633 Canoga Ave., is contaminated with trichloroethylene, tetrachloroethylene and total petroleum hydrocarbons that were left from decades of rocket manufacturing, according to the water board.

Last year, United Technologies Corp filed a letter with the board, asking to allow remediation to a commercial standard, which is lower than the residential level. The Rocketdyne site is zoned for residential use and has been advertised as a high-rise urban district.

“This site needs to be fully cleaned up to residential standards,” said Faith Larson, a Winnetka resident. “Valley residents should not have to continue living next to a property that poses environmental and health risks. Environmental regulators should not let UTC off the hook.”

During the rally Thursday, residents and organizers called on Los Angeles Councilman Bob Blumenfield, state Sen. Henry Stern, and Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel to hold the landowner accountable.

“UTC knows that the former Rocketdyne site was rezoned for mixed-use years ago, which means that they fully understand their responsibility to ensure the health and safety of future occupants and neighbors,” Blumenfield

said in a statement. “Regardless of who it is sold to or what is built there, a complete and thorough environmental clean-up of this site is imperative before any permits are issued.”

Blumenfield said he is “concerned by the prospect of UTC trying to get a covenant to not allow housing in order to neglect their environmental obligations. This is simply wrong as we are still in a housing crisis and that the land needs to be cleaned up one way or another.”

The site was once the place where hundreds of scientists contributed to space exploration.

The former site is one of multiple facilities in the west San Fernando Valley where activists have been concerned about contaminants.

Other sites include the 2,850-acre Santa Susana Field Lab near Chatsworth and West Hills known for the development of rocket engines such as the Delta II. The area became the site of a partial nuclear meltdown in the 1950s.

Activist also have rallied against a Southern California Gas facility in Aliso Canyon, tucked in the hills above Porter Ranch. The facility had a massive natural gas leak that released tons of methane into the air in 2015 and 2016. Activists and neighbors have been advocating for shutting down the facility.

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